DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Can Evil Be Good for Us?

Daat Tevunot §124

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §124 (to the end of Section 5) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 27 April 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the cogs

The class resumed in the middle of §124, at the foot of page 288. Most of the universe works from above to below, but God created man with the ability to influence what is above. We are part of an interconnected system, where one thing triggers another. Evil is part of that system. By itself it is bad; seen as part of the whole, pressing other buttons and triggering other things, we see how it all works out.

Evil was created in order one day to be destroyed, so we must look at it from two perspectives: the period of its existence, the 6,000 years, and the period of its destruction. During the 6,000 years it really is evil, both the tragedies that happen and the temptations people face. From the perspective of the end, "gam zo letovah", it is actually for the good. The Ramhal now gives several reasons.

Five ways evil serves the good

1. The light is appreciated more. The more darkness, the greater the light when it is revealed. Come into a lit room from a dark one, and the light is intense; come in from the sunshine, and you hardly notice it.

2. A greater revelation of Yihud Hashem. The whole purpose is to reveal that all the darkness was part of HaKadosh Barukh Hu's plan, so the more darkness there was, the greater the revelation of His oneness at the end. But the Rabbi warned: do not go looking for darkness. "If I manage to have light without electricity, then you don't need to go have the dark in order to have the contrast." If you can reach Yihud Hashem by yourself, that is best.

3. The profit of the test. The Ramhal brings a parable from the Zohar. A king wanted to test his son's faithfulness. He told him he could do anything except sin with a woman, and then brought the most beautiful woman to seduce him. The son stood firm, and the king rewarded him with everything. Was that woman good or bad? She was bad. But ask the son at the end of his life, and he will say she was good for him: all his wealth and power came through her. So too, from evil we gain.

4. Partnership with God. Evil gives us work: the ability to rectify the world and remove its bad. That makes us partners with HaKadosh Barukh Hu. The Rabbi explained that "partner in

creation", as said of Friday night, means becoming godly, more connected to Him. Because there is evil to repair, we can repair it and so become closer to Him.

5. The test of faith. This is the deepest. Hashem watches over the world with justice, "a God of faithfulness without iniquity". Yet He runs the world in a way that sometimes looks like the opposite: as if everything is chance, the wicked prosper, and those who serve God cry out and are not answered. King David said, "my feet almost slipped", when he saw the wicked at ease. That is the test: will people stand firm in their faith and not let go of the foundation in their hearts, saying "certainly He is a faithful God, though we cannot see it"? This is what Habakkuk means: "vesaddik beemunato yihyeh", the righteous shall live by his faith.

Action and thought

The Rabbi contrasted reason 3 and reason 5. The first is a test of action, temptation to sin. The second is a test of thought, of philosophy, and "the thought is more difficult. Always. Actions you can control." Think of the relationship with God of those who stayed faithful through all the difficulties, and how great their reward will be. Even the greatest concealment is for His glory in the end.

The Gemara says that a bad thought is not counted as a deed: if I plot a crime but never act, I am not liable. But in matters of faith it is different, because there the sin is the thought itself, as with idolatry, and as with "do not stray after your hearts".

A participant asked about passing thoughts. The Rabbi said initial thoughts come, and there is nothing wrong with them; dwelling on them and fantasising is the problem. The Gemara advises that if the yeser hara attacks you, "draw it to the beit midrash." He noted that mental health practice teaches the same: negative thoughts will come, and the question is whether you build them up or learn to redirect them. A participant added that if you have not guarded your eyes, you bear some responsibility for the thought that follows, and the Rabbi agreed.

Only within the system

The Ramhal then says that evil turning to good is only understandable through the analogy of the cogs, which turn everything towards the good. Evil without the system is simply destruction. But as part of the system, it can serve the development of humanity. That is why man needs inclinations and desires: not to be swayed by them but to withstand them.

One person and the world

A participant asked: if I overcome evil but two others are swept along by it, the cogs move the other way, so do we never progress? The Rabbi answered that there are two systems, your own personal system of cogs and that of the world. This is why the Gemara and the Rambam in Hilchot Teshuvah teach that a person should see the world as balanced half and half, so that his one deed can tip it. "Your one vote can make a difference." And you also have your own whole mechanism within you.

The end of Section 5

When God set up the world, He set up a time of work, created evil in all its aspects for that work, and created the system by which evil will in the end be banished and man elevated. All knowledge of good and bad is needed for the development of humanity, until "the end product", the final tikkun. Until then evil is for your good, if you overcome it. After it is banished, the tranquility will be eternal. "How beautiful."

Section 6 will discuss Adam before and after the sin, and how evil fits into it.

Summary

- From the perspective of the end, evil is for the good, though in its own time it is truly evil.
- It makes the final light brighter and the revelation of God's oneness greater, but we should not seek darkness to get there.
- It gives us tests that earn reward, and work that makes us partners with God.
- The hardest test is faith when the wicked prosper; "the righteous shall live by his faith", and thought is harder to master than action.
- All this holds only when evil is seen as a cog within the whole system; each person can tip both his own world and the whole world.

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